

Australia Daily Brief

Monday, September 21, 2026

1,992 words · 8 min read

RE: NZ navy transits Taiwan Strait · Plan Tasman signed · Peters' valedictory: nuclear-free policy 'had costs' · Albanese opens UNSC bid · Newpoll slides · NZ-India FTA from October 20

ASX 200

8,732

-0.21%

AUD/USD

0.7130

-0.11%

NZX 50

13,821

+1.92%

NZD/USD

0.5727

-0.90%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 New Zealand's navy transited the Taiwan Strait and signed the Plan Tasman pact with the Royal Australian Navy on the same day outgoing Foreign Minister Winston Peters told parliament the nuclear-free policy carried real strategic costs.
- 2 Albanese opened Australia's campaign for a UN Security Council seat in New York, named former News Corp executive Siobhan McKenna consul-general, and faces a Newpoll showing Labor support collapsing.
- 3 New Zealand's free trade agreement with India takes effect October 20, and South Pacific defence ministers met in Fiji, while the UAE joined the Pacific Islands Forum as a strategic partner.

• TOP STORIES

NZ-DEFENSE

New Zealand naval ships transit contested Taiwan Strait

New Zealand naval vessels transited the contested Taiwan Strait, Reuters reported. The passage lands the same day Wellington formalised closer naval integration with Canberra under Plan Tasman, and as outgoing Foreign Minister **Winston Peters** pressed publicly for a strong continuing US role in the Pacific. Reuters carried the transit, the naval pact, and the Peters intervention as three separate filings from the region on one day.

per Reuters: "New Zealand naval ships transit contested Taiwan Strait"

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY

Peters says nuclear-free policy 'costs did occur' in final speech as foreign minister

Winston Peters used his final speech as Foreign Affairs Minister to argue New Zealand's anti-nuclear policy constrained as well as enlarged the country's agency, saying it "bolstered our national self-esteem" but that "costs did occur." Peters, in office since 2023, said he had conducted foreign policy "in uncertainty's shadow," criticised the underfunding of the diplomatic network, and rejected the idea that independence means only disagreeing with Washington, citing the anti-nuclear stance and the 2003 Iraq decision.

per RNZ: "'Costs did occur' with nuclear-free policy, Winston Peters says" · also Reuters

AU-DEFENSE

Australia and New Zealand sign Plan Tasman naval pact

The two navies signed Plan Tasman, covering personnel, training, development, warfighting, engineering, regulation and international engagement. Royal Australian Navy Deputy Chief Rear Admiral **Darren Grogan** said it "provides a practical framework to strengthen the way we train, operate and develop capability together." Royal New Zealand Navy Deputy Chief Commodore **Karl Woodhead** said the strategic guidance is "to deepen and formalise the alliance," describing the plan as "a shift from a history of cooperation based on tradition to integration by design" in a maritime relationship *more than 160 years* old.

per RNZ: "New Zealand and Australia deepen naval partnership" · also Reuters

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Albanese launches Australia's bid for UN Security Council seat

Anthony Albanese launched Australia's campaign for a two-year non-permanent seat on the UN Security Council, saying Australia is "in a pretty strong position" with Finland the only other nominee for two available spots. The secret ballot falls in mid-2028 and requires a *two-thirds majority* of UN General Assembly members. Albanese cited Australia's social media restrictions for minors as evidence of middle-power weight and named former News Corp executive **Siobhan McKenna** as the next consul-general in New York.

per ABC News: "Australia launches campaign for two-year seat on UN Security Council" · also SMH

• OVERNIGHT

AU-DEFENSE

[Australia says it protects technology after F-35 parts diversion report](#) · AFP

Australia said it protects sensitive technology after reporting that classified Australian F-35 fighter parts disappeared in Hong Kong. Australian Defence Magazine carried the underlying account of the diversion. Neither filing specifies the number of components involved or the date of the loss, and no investigating agency has been named.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

[Olmert blasts lack of charges over Zomi Frankcom killing](#) · SMH Federal Politics

Former Israeli prime minister **Ehud Olmert** said the Israeli military bears a "terrible criminal responsibility" for the drone strike that killed the Australian aid worker **Zomi Frankcom** and six colleagues, and called the absence of charges "obnoxious" and "unbelievable." Matthew Knott reported the comments for the Sydney Morning Herald.

AU-DEFENSE

[Chinese CCTV maker's cameras resurface in Australia inside EVs](#) · ABC Politics

Cameras made by Dahua Technology, stripped from federal government buildings and defence sites in 2023 over surveillance concerns, are fitted to the Leapmotor C10 sold in Australia since 2024. The car carries six cameras covering its surrounds and interior. Former national cybersecurity adviser **Alastair MacGibbon** said a strategically parked EV could record when staff enter and exit a government building and map working hours.

AU-DEFENSE

[Hacker takes remote control of BYD ute in Four Corners test](#) · ABC News

Four Corners asked car cybersecurity specialist **Dan Hreszczuk** to hack a BYD Shark 6 plug-in hybrid; he killed the headlights while the vehicle was moving on a road outside Canberra, and activated wipers and a microphone. "It was easier than we were expecting," Hreszczuk said. The Shark had no password on a digital access point. EVs and plug-in hybrids make up *almost a third* of new car sales this year, more than half of them Chinese brands.

AU-POLITICS

[Newspoll records collapse in support for Labor and Albanese](#) · The Australian

Newspoll recorded a collapse in support for Labor and for **Anthony Albanese**, The Australian reported, landing while the prime minister is in New York for the UN General Assembly. The paper separately assessed that Albanese "faces a summer of discontent" as migration and cost-of-living pressures build.

AU-POLITICS

[Turnbull says Australia is 'deluding' itself on AI copyright protection](#) · AFR

Former prime minister **Malcolm Turnbull** said Australia is deluding itself on protecting copyright from AI training, and believes Labor is "edging towards" a model in which copyright owners must opt out of having their data used. The intervention lands as Canberra drafts national AI standards.

• STAT OF THE DAY

0.9%

Projected annual Australian population growth, next 40 years

The 2026 Intergenerational Report halves the 1.4 percent average of the past four decades, just as both major parties campaign to cut migration further.

ABC News

• PACIFIC WIRE

VANUATU · ABC PACIFIC

[Vanuatu revokes Andrew Tate's purchased citizenship](#)

Vanuatu's government confirmed it revoked the citizenship and passport issued to **Andrew Tate**, bought in 2022 under the country's citizenship-by-investment scheme. Tate and his brother Tristan are in a Miami jail after

Britain sought their extradition on charges of rape, assault and facilitating trafficking for sexual exploitation. **Glen Craig**, who led a commission of inquiry into the scheme three years ago, said Tate should never have been granted citizenship.

REGIONAL · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

American Samoa and Guam resist federal deep-sea mining push

Leaders of American Samoa and Guam are pushing back against federal efforts to open surrounding oceans to deep-sea mining, arguing Washington cannot rush into commercial seabed extraction without regard for island communities that depend on the ocean for survival. Both are US territories outside the Pacific Islands Forum membership.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Fiji declares national HIV emergency

Fiji declared a national HIV emergency, which Islands Business describes as one of the sharpest increases in new infections globally. The declaration comes two years after Fiji's earlier action on the outbreak, according to the report.

FIJI · ABC PACIFIC

Yasawa islands face facility shutdowns as water sources dry up

Thousands of people in Fiji's Yasawa islands face severe water shortages as natural water sources dry up in an unusually strong El Nino, with facilities shutting down. ABC Pacific Beat reported the drought alongside other Pacific items.

SAMOA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Fijian medical company breaks ground on private hospital in Savai'i

PSH Hospitals, a Fijian medical company, has started groundwork on a private hospital in Savai'i, Samoa. Separately, Samoa conferred the chiefly title Tagaloafaaofonuu on Pacific Specialist Healthcare founder **Parvish Kumar** for his contribution to regional healthcare.

NIUE · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Niue Ocean Wide Trust presses its conservation finance model

Coral Pasisi, vice chair of the Niue Ocean Wide Trust, said the trust sought "finance that matched the length of that responsibility" rather than protection "dependent on the next grant." The trust sells Ocean Conservation Commitments to individuals, companies and governments toward a *\$32 million* endowment for permanent ocean protection. Five Earthshot Prize winners are announced in November in Mumbai.

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Pacific states coordinate at FAO fisheries committee

Pacific Island countries and territories acted as a bloc on sustainable fisheries management at the 37th session of the Committee on Fisheries, Islands Business reported. Fisheries revenue underwrites national budgets across much of the region.

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Forum leaders to press Pacific priorities at UNGA81

Pacific Islands Forum leaders will elevate regional priorities on the global agenda at UNGA81, per the PACNEWS bulletin, which also flags the Pacific Media Summit setting direction for the next decade of Pacific media and a Savusavu town hall where Fiji's deputy prime minister faces climate and environment questions during the PINA summit.

India-New Zealand free trade pact takes effect October 20

The India-New Zealand free trade agreement enters into force on October 20, Bloomberg reported, after both governments ratified it. The Beehive confirmed ratification in a ministerial release. Implementation lands weeks before New Zealand's November 7 general election.

REUTERS

Peters urges a strong US role in the Pacific

Winston Peters urged Washington to maintain a strong presence in the Pacific, Reuters reported, on the same day he delivered his final speech as foreign minister. The call follows the Forum's contested handling of a statement on Chinese missile activity in the region.

RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Air New Zealand pilot altercation in US reported to aviation regulator

An altercation between two off-duty Air New Zealand pilots in the United States has been reported to the Civil Aviation Authority, which said it will determine whether regulatory action is required. Chief safety and risk officer McGraw said there was "no incident onboard the aircraft." San Francisco to Auckland departures were cancelled on September 6 and 7.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

REGIONAL · OTHER · SOUTH CHINA MORNING POST

SCMP commentary casts Pacific states as trapped in 'Cold War 2.0'

A South China Morning Post opinion piece argues Pacific island states are caught inside a renewed great-power contest, framing regional diplomacy as a Cold War sequel. The framing runs against Forum members' insistence on choosing partners rather than sides.

REGIONAL · OTHER · ABC POLITICS

US absence of resident ambassadors questioned as China courts Pacific

Independent journalist **Anna Fifield** told ABC's Global Roaming that China and the United States are vying for allies in the Pacific islands, and asked whether Washington can be taken seriously as a diplomatic force given it has lacked a resident ambassador in a Pacific island nation for more than a decade.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Albanese defends McKenna's New York appointment as made on merit

Anthony Albanese defended appointing former News Corp executive **Siobhan McKenna** to the New York consul-general post, insisting the decision was made entirely on merit. McKenna replaces **Heather Ridout**, whose term expires at the end of this year, the AFR reported.

ABC NEWS

Migration and data centres become Labor's twin political liabilities

Data centres and migration are the two inputs propping up growth and the two issues voters are most hostile to, the ABC's political analysis argues. The Intergenerational Report projects population growth slowing from an average of 1.4 percent a year over the past 40 years to 0.9 percent a year over the next 40. One Nation and the Coalition are pressing for deeper migration cuts.

THE AUSTRALIAN

Gallagher backs PM in handing Indigenous child safety crisis to WA

Katy Gallagher backed the prime minister's position that the Indigenous child protection crisis is a matter for Western Australia, The Australian reported, as a former welfare officer detailed neglect of Indigenous babies in South Hedland. Albanese invoked Indigenous history in his UN Security Council pitch the same week.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

AFR

Intergenerational Report projects deaths outnumbering births by the 2060s

Deaths will outnumber births by the 2060s and net overseas migration will stabilise at lower levels, the 2026 Intergenerational Report projects. The Australian reports the document forecasts deficits across the next 40 years and student debt doubling by 2065. An AFR analysis puts Australians *\$14,500 poorer* than Peter Costello forecast in 2002.

WSJ

Bullock says inflation fears are materialising

Reserve Bank governor **Michele Bullock** said the inflation fears the bank had flagged are materialising, the Wall Street Journal reported. The RBA cash rate stands at 4.35 percent after a second consecutive hold on August 11. The ASX 200 closed at 8,732, down 0.21 percent; Brent fell 7.94 percent to 97.43.

• PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

READOUT · NZ MINISTERIAL

South Pacific Defence Ministers meet in Fiji

The New Zealand government released a statement on the South Pacific Defence Ministers' Meeting held in Fiji. The gathering follows Wellington's signature of the Plan Tasman naval pact with Australia and precedes New Zealand's November 7 election.

MINISTERIAL TRANSCRIPT · AU MINISTERIAL

Wong announces new ambassador to Timor-Leste

Foreign Minister **Penny Wong** announced Australia's next ambassador to the Democratic Republic of Timor-Leste, alongside a separate appointment to Egypt. Timor-Leste's accession process to ASEAN and its maritime boundary and gas negotiations with Australia sit in the posting's brief.

• UPCOMING

OCT
20

India-New Zealand free trade agreement enters into force

Tariff schedules begin applying to New Zealand exporters weeks before the general election.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election, advance voting from October 26

Winston Peters has delivered his final speech as foreign minister, putting the foreign and defence portfolios in play.

NOV
2026

Earthshot Prize winners announced in Mumbai

The Niue Ocean Wide Trust is a finalist and a win would capitalise its ocean conservation endowment.

• THE WIRE

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

LOWY INTERPRETER

Solomon Islands: how 100 days of Wale reshaped its foreign policy

Solomon Islands' new prime minister has reset ties with Canberra and courted the wider world, while his domestic position remains precarious, the Lowy Interpreter argues.

ABC NEWS

Lowy Institute Media Award goes to ABC's Stephen Dziedzic

Stephen Dziedzic won the 2026 Lowy Institute Media Award for coverage of Australian government policy and deal making with Pacific island nations. The ABC investigation Foreign Correspondent: Cartel Paradise, reported with Pacific Local Journalism Network correspondents **Lice Movono**, **Chrisnrita Aumanu-Leong** and **Marian Kupu**, was shortlisted.

TRADE-ECONOMY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Randomising our way to better policy

Andrew Leigh, Assistant Minister for Productivity, Competition, Charities and Treasury, makes the case for directing money to interventions with evidence behind them, drawing on tax reform in the Democratic Republic of the Congo and minibuses in Kenya.

AU-DEFENSE

LOWY INTERPRETER

Why "Australian AIs only" is harder than it sounds

AUSTEO classification can mark a secret as protected but says nothing about who controls the capability that secret becomes, the Interpreter argues, as Canberra drafts national AI standards.

AU-POLITICS

ASPI STRATEGIST

Australia's multiculturalism is a precious achievement

A former Australian ambassador to Greece, who arrived in Australia in 1981 aged 12, argues multiculturalism is a national asset, published as both major parties compete to cut migration.

OTHER

AFR

Australia should demand early access to America's frontier AI

The AFR argues Canberra should request testing-phase access to US frontier AI models as a guard against models running amok, a live question as Albanese pushes AI guardrails at the UN.

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AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

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